the ambassador was not willing to give up so easily. He was heard later saying at an informal gathering that Chavan's tongue could not have been slipping for five minutes.

But criticism was mounting, with no news of Sivarasan. New Delhi questioned the progress of the SIT, as none of their raids had produced the desired results. The argument behind questioning the SIT was that Sivarasan had not even fled after assassinating Rajiv Gandhi but was also already readying to strike at three more VIPs. Intelligence reports revealed that Sivarasan had planted two assassins in the state guest house in the capital. But this was unsubstantiated since even sustained interrogation of the two LTTE cadres, Athirai and Kanagasabapathy, did not reveal anything to confirm this diabolical plan. They were in the capital as part of Plan B to kill Rajiv Gandhi.

Kaarthikeyan proudly backed his team. In a meeting at the PMO, he stressed that thanks to his team, major LTTE establishments in the state had been wiped out. There had been a rich haul of arms, explosives, high-powered communication gadgets and money. Also, more than thirty of their members were either dead or cooling their heels in prison. The fact that Sivarasan had become a liability for the LTTE was a big achievement for the SIT. It was established news by then that Jaffna hadn't sent a boat for Sivarasan despite the latter's repeated requests. And if reports of the IB and the R&AW were anything to go by, the LTTE bosses in Jaffna were not happy to see their carefully created empire in Tamil Nadu crashing like a house of cards. Yet, the spirit of a section of the political wing of the LTTE in Tamil Nadu was so high that keeping Sivarasan away from the SIT did not seem difficult. A major concern for the SIT at that point was that in the event of getting nabbed, Sivarasan would bite the cyanide pill that always hung around his neck.

Using computer-generated imagery (CGI), the SIT conjured up over a dozen faces of Sivarasan both with one eye and in disguises that showed him as a Sikh, a maulvi, a Hindu priest and a parish priest, and released them in newspapers. They printed thousands of flyers with photographs of Shubha and Nero, and distributed them to drivers of autorickshaws and